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JUGGERNAUT



The seafront at Puri, with the temple of Jagannath in the distance, as drawn in a watercolour by an unknown European artist in September 1820.

JUGGERNAUT A corruption of the Skt. *Jagannatha*, 'Lord of the Universe', a name of Krishna worshipped as Vishnu at the famous port of Puri in Orissa. The image is called an amorphous idol … and it has been plausibly suggested (we believe first by General Cunningham) that it was in reality a Buddhist symbol, which has been adopted as an object of Brahmanical worship, and made to serve as an image of a god. It was, and is, annually dragged forth in procession in a monstrous car, and as masses of excited pilgrims crowded round to drag or accompany it, accidents occurred … The popular impression in regard to the continued frequency of immolations on these occasions – a belief that has made *Juggernaut* a standing metaphor – was greatly exaggerated.